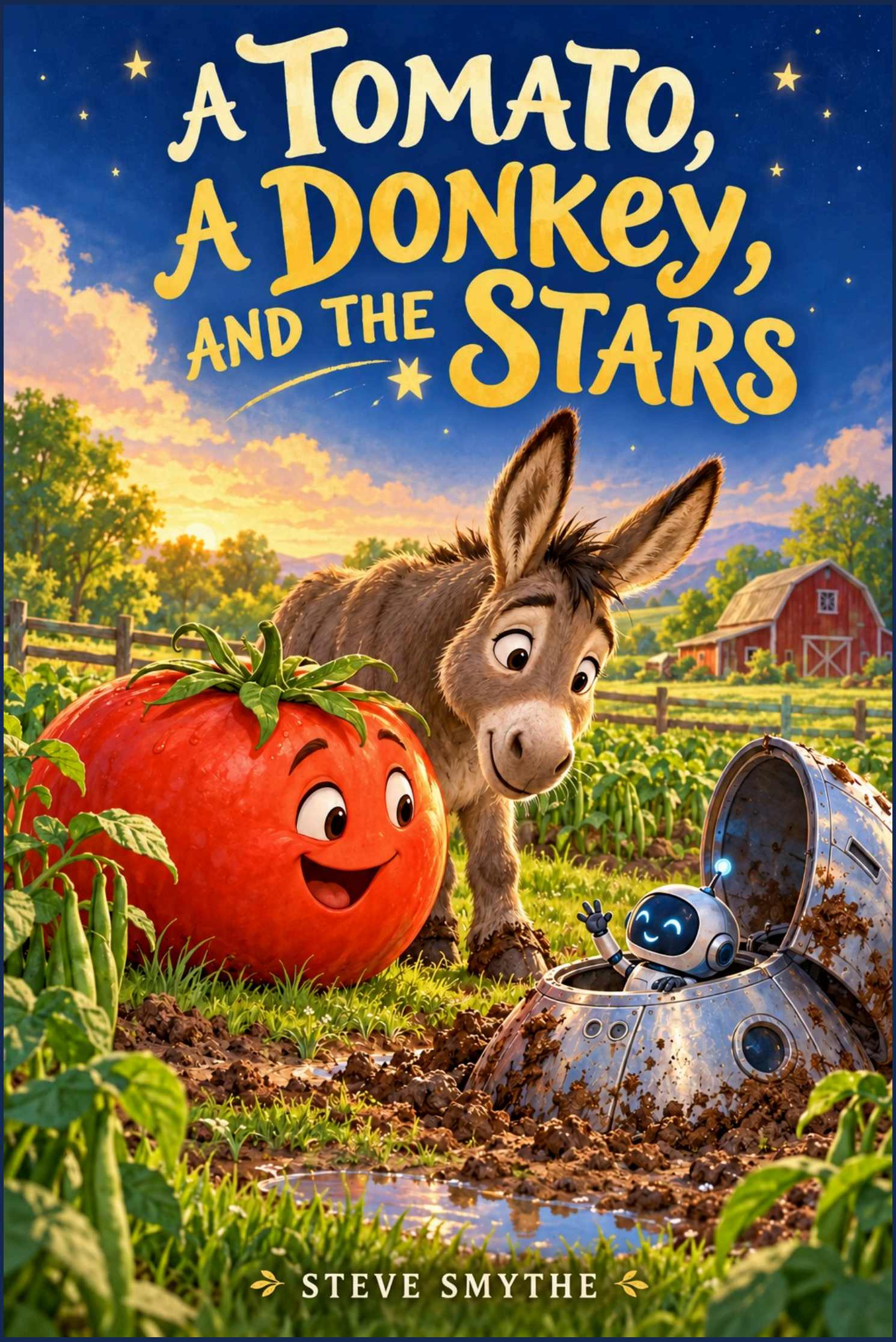

A TOMATO, A DONKEY, AND THE STARS
STEVE SMYTHE

A CHILDREN'S CHAPTER BOOK

A TOMATO, A DONKEY, and the Stars

STEVE SMYTHE

AI GLOBAL ENTERTAINMENT

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ABOUT THIS DRAFT

A Tomato, a Donkey, and the Stars is a working draft — a children's chapter book by Steve Smythe, produced with RoughDraft Maker from his original story. It is complete as a story — beginning, middle, and end, in twenty-six chapters — and deliberately unfinished as a book. Chapter One is written at full weight; the chapters that follow are shorter and leaner, the way first drafts are: the adventure, the jokes, and the heart are on the page, waiting for a writer's second pass — and, one day, an illustrator's.

That is not an apology. It is the product working as intended. RoughDraft Maker takes a writer from a blank page to something real they can edit — because writing is rewriting. Longer drafts exist, up to roughly 64,000 words, and every one of them, this one included, still asks for a human at the desk.

We don't write finished novels. We help writers start them — partners in the draft, like a trusted friend over coffee. Your story stays yours.

CONTENTS

Chapter 1 — The Wrong Kind of Stone 6
Chapter 2 — A Very Small Passenger 17
Chapter 3 — A Place to Rest 20
Chapter 4 — Three Things Gone Wrong 23
Chapter 5 — A Pull Too Soon 26
Chapter 6 — One Plan, Three Friends 30
Chapter 7 — The Shed Full of Maybe 33
Chapter 8 — Hold Still, Pip 36
Chapter 9 — The Trouble with Mud 40
Chapter 10 — A Dot in the Sky 43
Chapter 11 — Where the Sun Goes 46
Chapter 12 — The Hill Test 49
Chapter 13 — A Ride for the Morning 52
Chapter 14 — Up Before the Sun 56
Chapter 15 — The Waiting Job 60
Chapter 16 — A Sky Full of Elsewhere 64
Chapter 17 — The Long Grey Cloud 68
Chapter 18 — No More Guessing 71
Chapter 19 — Grass in the Fan 74
Chapter 20 — A Little Room for Air 77
Chapter 21 — The Uneven Ground 81
Chapter 22 — A Place to Stand 84
Chapter 23 — Things to Say Before Dawn 88
Chapter 24 — The Last Careful Step 91
Chapter 25 — A Small Light Going Up 94
Chapter 26 — Three Taps from Far Away 98

Chapter 1

The Wrong Kind of Stone

Pip wanted a big job.

Not a small job that someone called big to be kind. A proper big job.

He was a giant tomato, after all. He was nearly as wide as the rain barrel beside the barn. When he sat in the vegetable patch, he shaded six carrots and most of a beet.

The beet had complained.

That morning, Pip had rolled out of the patch before anyone could ask him to move. Rain had fallen all night. Now the farm smelled of wet earth, and drops of water shone on the bean poles.

Beyond the fence, the grass looked washed and new.

Near the barn, it looked like soup.

Pip stopped at the edge of a puddle. A red tomato looked back at him from the brown water. A green star of leaves sat on top of its head.

"You look ready," Pip told it.

A drop fell from the barn roof.

Plop.

The other tomato broke into wobbly pieces.

"Pip!"

Bramble stood beside the lower field. Her long ears rose above the fence. Mud covered her hooves.

"Can you come here?"

Pip turned toward her.

"What sort of job is it?"

"A wet one."

"Is it important?"

"The bean patch is filling with water."

That sounded important. Beans could not swim. At least, Pip had never seen one try.

He rolled along the path. Moving downhill was easy. Stopping at the bottom took more care.

"Slowly," Bramble called.

"I am going slowly."

"You are getting bigger quite quickly."

"That's because I'm coming closer."

"Exactly."

Pip leaned back. His leaves brushed the grass, and he came to a stop just short of Bramble's front hooves.

Bramble looked down at him.

Pip looked up at her.

"Perfect," he said.

"Nearly," she said.

A narrow ditch ran along the edge of the field. On most days, water trickled through it and away toward the pond. Today the ditch was full. A branch, a bundle of weeds, and a great lump of mud blocked the bend.

Behind the blockage, water had spread between the rows of beans.

Pip studied the branch.

"I can squash that."

"We need to move it, not squash it."

"I could squash it somewhere else."

Bramble's ears tipped forward.

"Let's start with moving."

She stepped down into the shallow ditch. Water closed around her hooves with a soft sucking sound.

Pip stayed on the grass.

There were many good things about being a giant tomato. Getting stuck in a narrow ditch would not be one of them.

Bramble took a twig between her teeth and tugged. The branch shook. A few leaves broke free, but the thick end stayed buried.

She let go.

"The mud is holding it."

Pip edged closer. From there, he could see a knot sticking out of the branch.

"If you loosen that end," he said, "I can push this bit away from the bank."

Bramble looked from him to the branch.

"That might work."

"It will work."

"It might," she said again. "Wait until I say."

She scraped mud away with one hoof.

Pip leaned against the knot.

The branch felt rough against his skin. He wanted to push. The beans were in a puddle, and here he was, ready to help.

But Bramble was still digging.

"Now?" he asked.

"Not yet."

A worm slid out of the mud.

Bramble stepped around it.

"Now?"

"Nearly."

Pip held still. A fly landed on his leaf.

He wished it had chosen a smaller tomato.

Bramble took one last step back.

"Now."

Pip pushed.

The branch gave a wet pop. He rolled forward half a turn, and brown water rushed through the gap.

"It worked!" he cried.

"Stay there."

Pip stopped.

The water pulled dead leaves and bits of grass past Bramble's legs. Then it began to wash loose mud from the bank.

Something under the mud made a dull silver flash.

Pip blinked.

"Bramble."

"I see it."

She lifted a hoof and scraped gently beside it.

Clang.

Both of them went still.

The sound hung in the wet morning air.

"That," Pip said, "was not a root."

"No."

"Roots don't clang."

"Not usually."

Bramble stepped out of the ditch. Water dripped from her tail.

Pip leaned over the edge.

A curved patch of metal showed through the earth. It was about as wide as one of Bramble's ears. Mud hid the rest.

"Treasure," Pip whispered.

"It could be an old bucket."

"A treasure bucket."

"Or a pipe."

"A treasure pipe?"

Bramble gave him a sideways look.

Pip tried to see more of the metal. It had no rusty spots. Even under the dirty water, it looked smooth and bright.

"Have you ever seen a pipe like that?"

"No," Bramble said.

Pip liked that answer.

He looked up the ditch. The water was running more freely now, but a little stream still curled around the strange thing.

"We should dig it out."

"We should find out how big it is first."

"That is what digging is for."

"And make sure the bank won't fall in."

Pip glanced down.

A piece of mud slid from the edge and plopped into the water.

He moved back a little.

Bramble noticed. She did not say anything.

That was one of the things Pip liked about her.

She walked along the bank, pressing each hoof down before putting her full weight on it.

Pip followed at a safe distance.

The ditch bent around a low rise. Grass covered most of it, but the side nearest them had split. Fresh brown earth showed beneath the torn roots.

"Was that there yesterday?" Pip asked.

"I don't remember it."

Neither did Pip.

He had passed this way yesterday afternoon. He remembered a yellow butterfly on the fence. He remembered trying to roll through the gate without touching either post.

He had touched both.

But he did not remember the split in the grass.

"Maybe the rain did it," he said.

"Maybe."

Pip studied the rise again.

He could imagine an enormous silver bucket under it.

He could also imagine a chest full of gold.

The chest was much more exciting.

Bramble returned to the exposed metal and scraped away a little more mud.

Another silver patch appeared.

Then another.

The curve continued under the bank.

"That's a very big bucket," Pip said.

Bramble made a soft sound through her nose.

"What?"

"I don't think it's a bucket."

Pip felt a pleasant tingle all the way to his leaves.

Here was something Bramble did not know.

Not because she had forgotten, or because Pip had asked a silly question. It was something new.

Something on their farm.

And they had found it together.

Bramble scraped again. Mud slid away, then water washed back over the spot.

She stopped.

"We're digging the same mud twice."

Pip looked at the stream.

It was still running straight past the metal. Each time Bramble cleared a patch, the water carried more dirt into it.

"We could tell the water to go somewhere else," he said.

"You can ask."

"I was thinking of making it."

He turned toward the ditch behind them. A shallow dip crossed the grass and led back into the ditch farther down.

Pip had once rolled into that dip and needed Bramble's help to get out. He had not liked it much at the time.

Now he looked at it with interest.

"What if the water went through there?"

Bramble followed his gaze.

She walked to the dip. Then she walked to its lower end.

Pip waited while she checked.

He could feel the waiting inside him, like a small creature hopping up and down.

At last Bramble nodded.

"We'd only need to open this end."

"And block that bit," Pip said.

"With something that won't wash away."

They both looked at the branch.

It lay on the grass with weeds still wrapped around it.

Pip grinned.

"I knew it had another job in it."

Bramble dragged the branch into place. Pip pushed against the thick end while she packed wet earth around it with her hooves.

Then she scraped a short channel into the dip.

For a moment, nothing happened.

A thin line of water crept through the new opening.

Then it widened.

The stream turned.

Pip watched it spill across the grass and run down to meet the ditch again.

"We moved a stream," he said.

"A small stream."

"A whole small stream."

Bramble's ears flicked.

"Yes," she said. "A whole one."

With the water out of the way, she could clear the mud more easily.

Pip stayed beside the branch. It shifted once, and he leaned against it until it settled.

From there, he watched the buried thing grow.

Not really grow, he reminded himself.

It had been that size all along.

They were just finding out.

The silver curve was longer than Bramble. One end was round. The other narrowed beneath a thick clump of grass.

There were no handles.

There was no open top.

Pip's treasure bucket began to seem less likely.

"Perhaps it's a very large egg," he said.

Bramble paused.

"Made of metal?"

"A very unusual egg."

"What would lay it?"

Pip thought about that.

He wished he had not.

"Let's hope we don't find out."

Bramble went back to work.

She cleared a groove along the side. It made a neat oval in the metal, like the edge of a little door.

Near it sat a round, dark window.

Pip forgot the branch and rolled closer.

"Careful," Bramble said.

He stopped on the firm grass.

The window was too muddy to see through. A small silver ring sat beneath it.

And above the ring were three marks.

Stars.

Not scratches that happened to look like stars. These were neat, five-pointed stars, each inside a circle.

Pip stared at them.

He had seen something like that before.

Last summer, an old seed box had stood in the barn. Someone had pasted pictures all over its lid. There had been a red train, a striped balloon, and a silver craft flying above the moon.

The silver craft had a little round window.

And stars painted on its side.

"Bramble," he said.

She looked up.

"I think it came from space."

Bramble turned back to the metal shell.

For once, she did not answer straight away.

Pip could hear a bird calling from the orchard. Farther off, water trickled along their new stream.

"Like a rocket?" Bramble asked at last.

"Like the little part people ride in."

"A capsule?"

"Yes." Pip liked the word. It seemed to fit the smooth silver shape. "A space capsule."

"Here?"

Pip looked around.

The bean patch. The crooked fence. The branch with weeds caught in it.

Their ordinary farm.

Then he looked back at the stars.

"Apparently."

Bramble lowered her head to the round window. She breathed on it and rubbed a small patch with the side of her nose.

Pip tried to see past her.

"What's in there?"

"It's dark."

"Dark like empty?"

"Dark like I can't see."

She stepped aside.

From the grass, Pip could see only a dull circle and his own red shape reflected in it. He leaned one way, then the other.

Nothing moved inside.

Perhaps it was empty.

Perhaps whoever had arrived had already gone.

He glanced toward the orchard.

The spaces between the trees suddenly seemed worth looking at.

"Do you think it's been here long?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"Do you think someone lost it?"

"I don't know that either."

"What should we do?"

Bramble studied the little door.

"We shouldn't pull things until we know what they do."

Pip looked at the silver ring.

He had been about to suggest pulling it.

"What about knocking?"

Bramble turned toward him.

"If it were a house," Pip said, "we would knock."

"That's true."

"And it has a door."

"That seems to be a door."

"And if someone is in there, they might be wondering why we're digging up their house."

Bramble looked at the capsule for another moment.

Then she lifted one hoof.

"Softly," Pip said.

Her ears tipped toward him.

"I was going to."

She tapped the metal.

Tink.

The sound was much smaller than before.

They waited.

Pip listened so hard that the farm seemed to get louder. He heard a fly buzzing near his leaves. He heard a drop fall from the fence.

Nothing came from the capsule.

"Try three," he whispered.

Bramble tapped again.

Tink. Tink. Tink.

They waited.

Pip began to feel foolish.

Perhaps they had spent the morning digging up a strange water tank. Perhaps the stars were only decorations.

Perhaps—

Tick.

Pip did not move.

Tick. Tick.

Three small sounds.

From inside.

Bramble's ears stood straight up.

Pip looked at her. Her eyes were fixed on the little door.

"You heard that?" he whispered.

"Yes."

"Was it you?"

"No."

"It wasn't me."

"I know."

Pip stared at the dark window.

The capsule was no longer treasure. It was not a funny silver egg or an exciting thing to pull out of the ground.

Something was inside it.

Something that had heard them.

He edged as close as the firm grass allowed.

"Hello," he said.

His voice came out smaller than he meant it to.

He tried again.

"Hello. I'm Pip. Bramble is here too."

The window stayed dark.

Pip looked at the mud packed around the door. There was a lot of it. More than he had noticed before.

"We found you," he said.

Behind the metal, something gave one soft tap.

Pip leaned toward the sound.

"All right," he said. "We're staying."

Chapter 2

A Very Small Passenger

The silver ring trembled.

Pip leaned forward. A thin line of darkness appeared along the little door, then vanished with a scrape.

"It's trying to open," he said. "Pull the ring!"

Bramble lowered her head, but stopped before her teeth touched it.

"There's dirt all along the bottom."

"Then pull hard."

"And drop it inside?"

Pip looked at the heavy lump beneath the door. Small roots ran through it. He imagined the whole thing landing on whoever had made that little tap.

"Perhaps not very hard."

"First we clear it."

Something scraped again.

"Wait!" Pip called. "There's a lump in the way. Not me. A mud lump."

Bramble glanced at him.

"It might be useful to explain," he said.

She tested the ditch floor with a hoof. The first spot sank beneath her weight. She moved farther along and tried again.

Pip wished she would hurry. But when she stood on the second spot, the first one folded into a puddle.

He stopped wishing quite so hard.

Bramble scraped below the door. Wet earth peeled away in thick curls. She pushed each curl aside before loosening another.

Pip watched a root stretch between the bank and the metal.

"That one's still holding."

"I see it."

She caught the root between her teeth and tugged it free. Dirt sprinkled her nose.

Pip would have laughed on an ordinary morning.

This did not feel like an ordinary morning anymore.

"Can you hear us?" he asked the door.

Tick.

"One means yes," Pip said.

"Or it means someone can tap once," Bramble said.

That was true. Pip hoped it meant yes.

At last the groove around the door was clear. Bramble stepped back.

"Try now," she said.

Nothing happened.

Pip stared at the ring.

Had they taken too long?

Then came a faint click.

The door swung outward a little. Bramble caught its edge with her nose and eased it away from the opening.

A small silver hand appeared.

Pip's leaves lifted.

The hand had three fingers. Each finger was no thicker than a bean stalk. It gripped the bottom of the doorway.

Another hand joined it.

Then a round head poked out.

Two yellow lights shone in a face as small as an apple.

"Oh," Pip said.

He had expected someone big enough to own a capsule longer than Bramble. Perhaps someone with boots.

This visitor could have worn a walnut shell as a hat.

It crawled onto the doorway, dragging two thin legs behind it. A square body followed. There was a dark little screen on its front.

"A robot," Pip whispered.

The head turned toward him.

"Very large," said the robot.

Its voice buzzed softly, like a fly trapped behind a window.

"I'm a tomato."

The yellow lights moved toward Bramble.

"Also large."

"Donkey," Bramble said.

The robot looked down at itself.

"Dot."

"Is that what sort you are?" Pip asked.

"Name."

"I'm Pip. I said that through the door, but perhaps doors make names sound different."

Dot lifted one hand.

Its elbow folded.

Before Pip could move, the robot tipped forward. Bramble slid her nose beneath its chest.

Dot lay across her muzzle with its feet hanging over one side.

Pip felt suddenly enormous. He could block a stream. He could shift a branch. But he could not catch something the size of an apple without squashing it.

Bramble held very still.

"Can you stand?" she asked.

Dot tried to lift its head. One yellow light blinked.

"Not well."

Pip looked from the muddy ditch to the tiny feet.

"We need somewhere better than this," he said.

Chapter 3

A Place to Rest

Pip searched the bank for a place that did not shine with water.

There was mud beside the capsule. Mud beside the fence. Mud in a hoofprint that was already filling up again.

Then he spotted a raised patch of grass beneath the hedge.

"There."

Bramble turned carefully. Dot still lay across her nose.

Pip rolled ahead, testing the patch with his weight. The grass bent, but no water squeezed out.

"Dry," he said. "Mostly."

Bramble knelt and lowered her muzzle to the grass. Dot crawled off one finger at a time.

Its square body made a faint ticking noise.

"Too bright," it murmured.

Sunlight reached through a gap in the hedge and fell across its face.

"I can shade you," Pip said.

He rolled between Dot and the gap. His shadow covered the robot, a tuft of grass, and a very surprised beetle.

Dot's lights stopped blinking.

"That helps."

Pip felt better at once.

Bramble looked toward the fence. An old empty feed sack hung over the lowest rail, where it had caught during the storm. She tugged it loose and dragged it over.

One side was damp. She turned it with her hoof until the dry side faced up, then spread it beside Dot.

Pip moved back so Bramble could lift one corner over a low fork in the hedge. The other edge rested on the ground.

It made a small brown roof.

Dot crawled beneath it.

"There," Pip said. "A house. Without a door to get stuck."

"Thank you."

Pip settled close enough to see inside.

"Did you really come from space?"

"Yes."

"How far?"

"Very."

"Farther than the pond?"

Dot's lights turned toward him.

"Yes."

"Farther than all the fields?"

"Pip," Bramble said.

"What? I'm finding out."

Dot shifted against a folded edge of sack.

"Beyond your moon."

Pip looked up. He could not see the moon now, but he knew where to imagine it.

All that way.

"Were you flying the capsule yourself?"

"Yes."

"What happened? Did you hit something? Was it the farm?"

The ticking inside Dot grew quicker.

"Lost... power. Came down."

"In the rain?"

Dot's face dimmed.

Bramble lowered her head beside Pip.

"Let it rest."

"One more question."

"You said that with your last question."

Pip had not actually said it. He had only thought it. That seemed rather unfair.

"Do you have a farm at home?" he asked.

Dot opened its mouth. A tiny crackle came out instead of a word.

Pip went still.

The yellow lights had shrunk to two dull spots.

"Speaking uses power," Dot whispered.

"Oh."

Pip wished he could gather his questions back. They suddenly seemed like things he had piled on top of the little robot.

"You don't have to answer."

Dot rested one hand against its chest.

The dark screen flickered.

A picture appeared, no bigger than a leaf. Pip leaned closer without touching the shelter.

He saw white towers under a purple sky. Little lights hung between them. At the bottom stood three small shapes with round heads and square bodies.

One raised a silver hand.

Dot touched the picture.

"Home."

The word was barely louder than the grass brushing Pip's skin.

He had been thinking about where Dot had come from. How far it had flown. What it had seen.

Now he looked at the waiting figures.

"Are those your friends?"

Dot nodded.

Pip let the next question stay inside him.

The picture faded, but he could still see the raised hand in his mind.

He settled beside the shelter and kept his shadow over its open side.

Chapter 4

Three Things Gone Wrong

After a while, a silver hand crept out from beneath the sack.

Dot held it in a patch of sunlight.

Pip watched without asking anything. This took more effort than he had expected.

The hand turned over. A dark strip on its back caught the light.

"Is that too bright?" Bramble asked.

"Face needs shade," Dot said. "Hands can gather power."

Pip looked at his own broad shadow. He had been very good at keeping sunlight away.

He edged aside.

Dot stretched both hands into the warm patch. For several minutes, nothing seemed to happen. A small ant climbed onto the sack. Pip watched it reach the top and come straight back down.

Then Dot's eyes grew brighter.

It sat up.

"Enough to check."

"The capsule?" Pip asked.

Dot nodded.

"Not enough to fly."

"Checking first," Bramble said.

Pip rolled beside them as Dot made its slow way to the ditch. Each step left a tiny square mark in the damp earth.

At the bank, Bramble offered her lowered nose. Dot climbed on, holding a tuft of hair, and she carried it down to the open door.

Pip watched from the grass.

Dot disappeared inside.

A click came from the capsule. Then a short scraping whine.

Pip leaned forward.

"Was that meant to happen?"

"No," Dot called.

The whine stopped.

A narrow panel beside the door sprang open. Behind it sat a little wheel with silver blades.

One blade stuck out at an odd angle.

"Cooling fan," Dot said from inside. "Bent."

Pip could see where the crooked blade touched the rim.

"What does it cool?"

"The parts that get hot when I fly."

"Could you fly very slowly?"

"Still hot."

Dot crawled back into the doorway and pointed above Pip.

He turned to look behind himself.

"Not there," Dot said. "Top of capsule."

"Oh."

Near the capsule's rounded end, a flat patch of glass lay under a smear of mud. Pip had taken it for another piece of metal.

"Star window," Dot said. "Helps the capsule find its way."

Pip looked at the round window beside the door.

"That's not the star window?"

"That is for looking out."

"Two windows. Sensible."

"Can the star window see through that mud?" Bramble asked.

"No."

Pip studied the brown smear. Mud did not seem much of an enemy. They had already moved plenty of it.

Dot pressed a button inside the doorway.

A small row of lights flashed red, then went dark.

The robot pressed again.

Nothing.

"Sun cell empty."

Pip waited.

Dot looked at him.

He remembered he was allowed to ask useful questions.

"What's a sun cell?"

"It stores sunlight as power. For the capsule."

"Like your hands?"

"Bigger."

That sounded promising. Pip liked bigger.

"So," Bramble said, "a bent fan, a muddy star window, and an empty sun cell."

"Three things," Dot said.

Pip looked along the silver shell.

Three things were not so many. There were more than three broken things in the tool shed, and most of those had been broken for ages without anyone looking particularly worried.

But Dot sat very still in the doorway.

"Cannot go home like this," it said.

Pip remembered the tiny figures beneath the purple sky.

"We'll fix everything."

Bramble turned toward him.

"Pip."

"We will."

Dot's lights lifted to his face.

"All three?"

"All three," Pip said.

The words felt big and solid when he said them.

Only afterward did he notice that he still had no idea how a sun cell filled up, or how a cooling fan came out.

Chapter 5

A Pull Too Soon

"We should get it out of the mud," Pip said.

That, at least, was a job he understood.

Bramble looked along the capsule. Its narrow end was still caught beneath the torn grass. The rounded end lay lower in the ditch.

"We'll need a rope."

"There's one by the gate."

"I know."

While she fetched it, Dot climbed down from the doorway and rested on a flat stone near Pip. Its feet hung over the edge.

Pip studied the capsule.

Once it was on the grass, everything would be easier. They could walk around it. Dot could reach all its little panels. Bramble would see that fixing everything had been a perfectly good thing to promise.

She returned with a coil of rope between her teeth.

Dot pointed to a thick metal loop near the narrow end.

"Pull there."

Bramble dropped the coil, then worked one end through the loop. Pip watched her catch it in her teeth and draw it back toward the bank.

The rope made a long doubled line.

"I can push the round bit," he said.

Bramble walked around to look.

The ditch was shallow there. A strip of firm ground sloped down to the capsule, wide enough for Pip to roll onto.

“From this side,” she said. “But don’t go below it.”

“I won’t.”

“If it slides, you need room to roll away.”

Pip glanced at the shell. It looked much too settled to slide anywhere.

Still, he chose a place beside the rounded end rather than directly beneath it.

Bramble nudged Dot’s stone.

“Stay up here.”

Dot tucked its feet onto the stone.

Pip rolled down the firm strip until his side touched cool metal.

He had found his job.

The capsule was large. He was large. This made far more sense than tiny buttons and tiny fingers.

Above him, Bramble took both rope ends in her teeth. She stepped backward until the slack lifted from the mud.

Pip leaned into the shell.

“Wait,” she said around the rope.

He eased back a little.

Bramble moved one hind hoof. Then the other.

Pip felt the capsule shift against him.

Only a tiny movement.

But it was moving.

If he pushed now, before it settled again, he could help it over the muddy ridge.

“I’ve got it!”

He shoved.

The capsule rolled sideways.

Not toward the grass.

Away from it.

The rope snapped tight. Bramble’s front hooves skidded, cutting two dark lines through the bank.

“Stop!”

Pip pulled his weight back.

For a dreadful moment, the silver shell kept turning.

Mud split beneath its lower end. The capsule dropped with a heavy squelch, and its open door swung hard against the frame.

Pip rolled away as a lump of earth fell where he had been.

The rope went slack.

Nobody moved.

"Dot?" Bramble called.

"Here."

Pip looked up.

The robot crouched on its stone with both hands pressed flat beside its feet.

Bramble let the rope fall.

"Pip?"

"I'm here."

"Are you hurt?"

He checked himself. Mud streaked his side. A bent leaf brushed his face.

"No."

Bramble walked down two careful steps and stopped.

The capsule now lay crooked, its rounded end sunk deeper than before. Brown water seeped into the hollow around it.

Pip stared at the metal he had pushed.

"I thought you were ready."

"I said wait."

"I know. But it moved, and I thought—"

His words ran out.

Bramble's breathing was loud beside him.

"If that rope had caught my leg, I couldn't have stepped away."

Pip looked at her muddy hooves.

"I'm sorry."

She stood beside him without answering at once.

He wanted to give the capsule another push. A better push. One that put everything back.

Instead, he stayed where he was.

"What should we do?" he asked.

Bramble looked at the sloping bank.

"First, we stop."

Pip kept still, although the crooked capsule made him want to move more than ever.

Chapter 6

One Plan, Three Friends

Bramble set the first board across the mud.

Pip watched its far end dip beneath a thin layer of brown water.

"That doesn't look firm."

"It isn't yet."

She lifted the end with her teeth and shifted it onto a buried stone. This time, when she pressed it with a hoof, the board stayed level.

There were three more boards on the grass. She had brought them from beside the tool shed while Pip stayed with Dot.

He had not touched the capsule.

He had looked at it a great deal.

Bramble laid a second board beside the first, making a wide track from the trapped capsule to the grass. Then she slid a shorter piece beneath their upper ends.

Pip waited for her to tell him where to go.

Instead, she looked at him.

"Where do you think your weight could help?"

He glanced at the rounded end of the capsule.

Then he looked away.

"Perhaps nowhere."

"That's not what I think."

"Last time—"

"Last time you pushed before I was ready." Bramble nudged the short board. "I'm asking about this time."

Pip studied the track. When Bramble tested one long board, its upper end lifted slightly.

He knew about things that wanted to lift.

"The short piece," he said. "I could lean on that. Keep these ends down."

"Without getting in the capsule's way?"

He followed the track with his eyes.

"From the side."

Bramble nodded.

"Let's try it before we pull."

Pip rolled onto the firm grass beside the short board. He leaned against its broad end. Bramble pressed the lower part of the track.

The boards creaked.

They did not lift.

"That helps," she said.

Pip stayed where he was.

Dot climbed down from its stone and pointed beneath the capsule.

"Rope must pull from the middle. Otherwise it turns."

Bramble adjusted the doubled rope through the metal loop. Then she used her hoof to scrape mud from beside the trapped end.

Pip watched every scrape.

"Tell me if this board moves," she said.

"I will."

"And I'll tell you before I pull."

She took up the rope and stepped onto firm ground.

Dot stood well away from the track.

"Ready here," it said.

Pip pressed against the short board.

"Ready here."

Bramble leaned back.

The rope tightened. For a moment, the capsule stayed exactly where it was.

Then something underneath gave a long sucking sound.

Its rounded end rose onto the boards.

Pip nearly cheered.

Instead, he said, "Still steady."

Bramble took another step.

Silver scraped over wood. Mud squeezed out on either side. The capsule came up the track slowly enough that Pip could watch each painted star pass.

At the top, Bramble stopped.

"Keep holding."

He did.

Dot checked beneath the shell. Bramble took one last backward step, and the capsule slid fully onto the grass.

"Clear," Dot said.

Only then did Pip ease away.

The boards had left a muddy stripe along his side.

He looked at it with interest.

A crackle came from inside the capsule.

Dot turned so quickly that one foot slipped.

"Radio!"

It scrambled through the open door. Pip heard clicking, then a voice that sounded as if it were speaking through dry leaves.

"Search ship... passing... dawn..."

The crackling swallowed several words.

"After one more day," the voice finished.

Then it stopped.

Pip stared through the doorway.

"Tomorrow morning?"

Dot shook its head.

"One whole day first. Then dawn."

Bramble's ears tipped forward.

"And they're looking for you?"

"Yes."

Pip looked at the capsule resting safely on the grass.

Someone was coming.

But the bent fan was still bent, the star window was still muddy, and the sun cell was still empty.

This time, he did not promise to fix everything.

"What do we need first?" he asked.

Chapter 7

The Shed Full of Maybe

"A small clamp," Dot said.

Pip looked around the tool shed.

There were hooks, buckets, boxes, and things that seemed to be mostly handle. Somewhere among them was a small clamp.

Probably.

"What does it look like?"

"Two jaws. A screw to close them."

Pip glanced at Bramble.

"Not your sort of jaws, then."

"Mine don't have a screw."

"That might be useful."

"Not for eating carrots."

Bramble pushed the shed door wider with her nose. Light spread across the floor, showing a curling strip of wood and three old nails.

Pip stopped at the threshold.

The doorway was wider than the vegetable gate, but not by much. A rake leaned just inside it.

"Could you move that?"

Bramble lifted the rake by its handle and set it against the far wall.

Pip rolled in carefully.

Nothing fell over.

That seemed a good beginning.

Dot sat on the low workbench beneath the window. Beside it lay the cooling fan, which it had unscrewed from the capsule with a tiny tool folded inside one finger.

Away from the ship, the fan looked even smaller.

Pip could have covered it with one leaf.

"We need to hold the middle," Dot said. "Then straighten the bent blade."

"Can you do that?"

"Not strong enough."

Bramble lowered her head to look.

"I might be."

"With a clamp," Dot said.

Pip began beside a wooden box on the floor. Inside were several metal things. One had a curved back and a screw sticking out of it.

"Found it!"

He leaned closer.

The box edge pressed against his skin. The clamp lay just beyond it.

He could see it perfectly.

He could not pick it up.

Pip tried nudging the box.

The tools rattled.

"Careful," Bramble said. "There are sharp bits in there."

He stopped.

Dot climbed down a stack of flat wooden blocks and came to inspect his find.

"Too large," it said.

Pip looked at the clamp again.

It had seemed quite small to him.

Bramble searched a shelf above his head. She moved a coil of string, then a cracked flowerpot.

"What about this?"

Between her teeth hung a little clamp with wooden pads covering its jaws.

Dot's eyes brightened.

"That one."

Bramble carried it to the workbench and set it beside the fan.

Pip looked back into the box.

He had found a clamp too. Not the right clamp, and he could not have carried it if it had been right.

Still.

"Anything else?"

"A cloth beneath the fan," Dot said. "So the small screws don't roll away."

A folded cloth lay on a shelf near Pip. He leaned toward it, caught its corner between two leaves, and lifted.

For one hopeful moment, it came with him.

Then it slipped off his leaves.

It landed over his face.

Bramble pulled it free.

"Thank you," Pip said.

"Were you looking for this?"

"I was carrying it."

"Briefly."

She laid the cloth on the bench.

Pip watched Dot climb back up. The robot arranged its little screws in a neat row while Bramble moved the clamp into place.

There seemed to be a great many useful jobs in a shed.

Most of them required picking something up.

Pip rolled closer to see.

His side touched a bench leg.

The whole bench rocked.

Dot caught the fan before it slid off the cloth.

Pip pulled away at once.

"Sorry!"

The bench rocked back.

One short leg hovered above the uneven floor.

Pip studied the gap beneath it. Then he looked at the empty space between the bench and the wall.

"Wait," he said. "I think there's something I can hold."

Chapter 8

Hold Still, Pip

Pip eased into the space beside the workbench.

A loose splinter stuck out from its leg. Bramble spotted it before he leaned close and pulled it away with her teeth.

"Now try."

Pip pressed his side against the wood.

"Like this?"

Dot pushed gently on the top.

The bench gave a small knock.

"More."

Pip leaned harder.

Dot pushed again.

This time there was no knock.

"Good."

Pip waited.

Nothing else happened to him.

On the bench, however, a great deal began to happen.

Dot set the fan inside the padded clamp. Bramble held the clamp steady with her nose while the robot turned its screw.

One turn.

Another.

A third, smaller turn.

Pip could see only the edge of the cloth and the tips of Bramble's ears.

"What are you doing now?"

"Checking the pads," Dot said.

"And now?"

"Still checking."

Pip settled his weight more firmly against the bench.

Holding still had sounded like a proper job when the bench was wobbling. Now it felt rather like being a bench leg.

He had left the vegetable patch to do something important.

Nobody ever congratulated a bench leg.

"Ready," Dot said.

Bramble bent her head.

Pip tried to lean just enough to see around her.

The bench clicked.

"Please don't move," Dot said.

He pressed back at once.

"Sorry."

Bramble lifted her head again.

"Can you keep that position comfortably?"

"Yes."

"Are you sure?"

Pip considered his side. The wood pressed against one spot, but it did not hurt.

"I can."

"Then we'll be quick, but not hurried."

Pip was not entirely sure how those two things were different.

He suspected Bramble was about to show him.

She took the bent blade between her front teeth.

"Only a little," Dot said.

Bramble moved her head so slightly that Pip could hardly see it.

"Stop."

She let go.

Dot turned the fan.

Scritch.

Pip heard the crooked blade catch.

"Still bent," he said.

"A little," Dot agreed.

Bramble lowered her head again.

Pip held his breath, although he was fairly certain bench legs did not need to do that.

There was a tiny squeak.

"Stop," Dot said.

Bramble let go.

The fan turned.

Scritch.

Not as loudly this time.

A fly landed on Pip's leaves.

He wished it would find a different repair shop.

The fly walked toward the middle of his leaf star. Pip wanted to shake it away. He nearly did.

Then he heard Dot's little feet shuffle on the cloth.

If the bench moved, Bramble's teeth might pull too far.

Pip kept still.

"Again," Dot said.

Bramble bent down.

The fly flew away.

For once, Pip thought very kindly of a fly.

"Try it now," Bramble said.

A soft whir came from the bench.

No scrape.

Dot spun the fan again.

Whir.

Pip felt the sound all the way to his leaves.

"Did we do it?"

Dot appeared at the edge of the bench, carrying the little wheel.

It blew across the blades.

They spun so smoothly that the silver edges blurred together.

"We did it," Dot said.

Bramble stepped back.

"You can move now."

Pip eased away from the leg. The bench gave its familiar knock.

Dot caught the clamp before it shifted.

Pip stared.

"Oh."

"Yes," Bramble said. "That would have been awkward with a fan in my teeth."

He looked at the spot where he had been bracing the wood.

It did not look important.

Neither did the muddy stripe on his side.

But the fan was turning.

"Tell me when you need the bench again," he said.

Chapter 9

The Trouble with Mud

By the time Dot had fitted the fan back inside the capsule, the mud on the star window had dried into a hard brown patch.

Pip could see tiny cracks across it.

"That should come straight off."

He knew where there was a sack.

Bramble had folded their little shelter after Dot no longer needed it. The sack lay nearby, with one corner still damp from the grass.

"Could you put that over my side?" Pip asked.

Bramble looked from him to the window.

"You mean to rub it?"

"It's a nice wide patch. I'm a nice wide tomato."

She spread one end of the sack across him, keeping the loose edge in her teeth.

Pip rolled close to the capsule.

"Stop," Dot said.

He stopped with the sack almost touching the brown patch.

"What?"

"Grit."

Pip looked down at the ground.

There was plenty of grit.

"In the mud," Dot said. "Hard little pieces. Rubbing will scratch the glass."

"Even with a sack?"

"The sack drags them."

Pip pictured all those little pieces scraping back and forth.

He eased away.

Bramble lifted the sack off him.

"Water, then?"

Dot nodded.

"Soft mud first."

Pip looked toward the barn roof. The sun had slipped lower while they worked in the shed. Its light no longer reached the ground beside the wall.

"How soft?"

"Soft enough to lift without scraping."

That was not a very exact answer.

Pip wanted an answer like three splashes, or until Bramble counted to ten.

Bramble brought a small bucket from beside the shed and filled it at the rain barrel. Water slopped over its rim as she carried it back.

Pip followed with a clean sponge she had found on a shelf. It rested in the hollow among his leaves.

He rolled slowly.

At the capsule, Bramble took the sponge and dipped it into the bucket.

Then she laid it against the muddy glass.

Water trickled down the silver shell.

Pip watched.

The brown patch grew darker.

"Now?"

"Not yet," Dot said.

Bramble held the sponge in place.

A drop fell from the bottom of the window.

Another followed.

Pip could hear each one land in the grass.

"We could do something else while it soaks."

Dot pointed to a dry strip along the upper edge.

"Watch there. Tell us if the water reaches it."

Pip leaned until he could see.

The water had gone around a little ridge of mud instead of over it.

"It's missing the top."

Bramble shifted the sponge.

"Better?"

"Left a bit."

She moved it.

"There."

Water spread across the dry strip.

Pip watched the colour change.

After a while, Bramble lowered the sponge into the bucket. She had to set it down to get a better grip on the handle, and the bucket tipped toward her.

Pip leaned against its side before it fell.

Cold water lapped over the rim and splashed him.

"Thank you," she said.

"I'm helping with the soaking."

"I can see that."

Dot tested the edge of the patch with one small finger. A soft brown curl lifted away.

Pip brightened.

But beneath it lay another layer.

"More water," Dot said.

Pip looked at the long shadow stretching from the fence.

The sun was still sinking.

He held the bucket steady while Bramble dipped the sponge again. Then he guided her back to the dry corner.

This time, he did not ask whether it was ready.

He watched until the last pale streak darkened, and told her where the water needed to go next.

Chapter 10

A Dot in the Sky

The last curl of mud slid off the star window.

Bramble rinsed the sponge and lifted away the brown water beneath it. Clear glass shone in the slanting light.

Pip leaned closer.

He could see something silver behind the glass. It looked like a little eye.

"Can it see now?"

Dot climbed through the capsule's door.

"Checking."

A faint hum came from inside. The silver eye turned. It pointed toward the open sky, paused, and turned again.

Pip stayed out of its way.

He had spent quite enough time being something nobody could see past.

A blue light appeared above the doorway.

Then the radio crackled.

"Search route confirmed," said the voice inside. "Meeting point follows."

A small picture lit up on the wall beside Dot.

Pip could see it through the door, but not very well. He edged left. Bramble lowered her head beside him.

The picture showed a curved green shape with a thin blue edge. Above it ran a dotted white line.

One bright spot moved along the line.

"Is that the search ship?" Pip asked.

"Yes."

"Where are we?"

Dot touched the green curve.

A much smaller spot blinked beneath its finger.

Pip looked from one spot to the other.

There was an awful lot of empty picture between them.

"They're not coming down?"

"No," Dot said.

"But they're looking for you."

Dot pressed a button. The moving spot left a pale trail behind it.

"They will listen as they pass. My little radio cannot reach them from the ground."

Pip looked up from the picture.

The sky over the farm seemed enormous. He had known it was enormous before, of course. But he had never needed to get something across it.

"What if we put the capsule somewhere tall?"

"How tall?" Dot asked.

"On the barn?"

Bramble's ears brushed the doorway.

"Let's not put it on the barn."

Dot shook its head.

"Much higher."

"How much higher?"

"Above the air you breathe."

Pip looked at Bramble.

She looked back at him.

That was considerably higher than the barn.

Dot touched a bright circle beside the dotted line.

"I must meet them here."

A thin yellow path stretched upward from the tiny farm spot. It ended inside the circle.

Pip followed it with his eyes.

"So the capsule has to fly."

"Yes."

"Not just work. Actually fly."

Dot looked around its little doorway.

"That is what working means for a capsule."

Pip supposed it was.

He had been imagining a repaired fan, a clean window, and Dot waving to a large ship that landed beside the bean patch.

The beans would have had something to say about that.

Now the picture showed Dot going up alone.

"When?" Bramble asked.

"At dawn, after tomorrow."

"The message said dawn," Pip said.

"This tells me exactly where at dawn."

Dot moved its finger along the yellow path.

"The clean window lets the capsule find the stars and follow the route. If I leave too late, the ship will already be past."

Pip stared at the bright circle.

"Can it come back?"

"I do not know when."

The hum inside the capsule faded. Dot lowered its hand, and the picture went dark.

Pip could still see the little circle when he blinked.

Bramble lifted her head out of the doorway.

"Then tomorrow matters."

Pip looked at the clean glass and the closed fan panel.

They had repaired two things.

Two real things.

But Dot did not need a tidy capsule sitting on the grass.

It needed a way into that circle.

"What will get you all the way up there?" Pip asked.

Chapter 11

Where the Sun Goes

"A full sun cell," Dot said.

It pressed a catch beside the doorway. A dark panel unfolded from the capsule's side.

Pip moved back as it opened.

The panel was made of neat little squares. They looked like pieces of black glass laid close together.

"This gathers sunlight," Dot explained. "The sun cell stores the power."

Pip studied the squares.

"How much sunlight?"

"A whole good day."

He looked toward the barn.

The sun had almost reached its roof.

"Well, we have a whole day tomorrow."

Bramble did not answer.

She walked around the capsule, watching the ground. Her shadow stretched ahead of her, long and thin.

Pip wished she would say that a whole day was plenty.

Instead, she stopped at the corner of the barn.

"Dot. Does bright shade count?"

"A little. Not enough."

Bramble looked up at the roof.

"This may be a problem."

Pip rolled beside her.

From there, he could see the dark edge of the barn's shadow creeping toward the capsule.

"That's only because it's evening."

"Yes. But where does the sun rise?"

Pip turned toward the orchard.

"Over there."

"And what's between there and the capsule?"

He followed the line back.

The barn.

"Oh."

The building had been useful all his life. It kept things dry. It held sacks and hay and interesting smells.

Now it seemed to be standing in entirely the wrong place.

"We can move the capsule around the other side."

Bramble led him to the corner.

On the other side stood the tool shed. Beyond that, apple trees crowded close to the fence.

Pip pictured the sun moving behind the branches.

"Not there, then."

Dot sat in the doorway with its hands in the last patch of light.

"The panel needs open sky. Especially early."

Pip looked across the yard.

There was open ground by the ditch, but the hedge stood along it. The vegetable patch caught plenty of sun in summer. Today, the bean poles cast thin bars of shade across half of it.

He tried to imagine the sun waiting politely while they found a place.

It did not seem likely.

Bramble turned toward the lower field.

"That ground is still wet."

"And the pond is worse," Pip said.

"I wasn't suggesting the pond."

"I'm ruling things out."

He rolled past her to see beyond the apple trees.

Above their rounded tops rose the grassy hill.

Its upper slope was still bright.

Pip stopped.

He knew that hill. From the vegetable patch, he could see its top whenever he leaned past the tallest bean pole. In the morning, light touched it before reaching the barnyard.

"What about there?"

Bramble followed his gaze.

"The hill?"

"No roof. No hedge. No bean poles."

Dot lifted its head.

"Open sky?"

"Lots of it," Pip said.

He almost added, Perfect.

Then he noticed how steep the nearest side looked.

Getting himself downhill was easy. Getting a capsule uphill would be something else.

Bramble walked beside him.

"There's a cart path beyond the orchard," she said. "It curves around the slope."

"So we wouldn't have to go straight up."

"No."

Pip pictured the capsule standing on the bright grass. He liked the picture.

But from here, he could not see whether the ground was flat. He could not see stones or holes. He could not even see the whole path.

"The top looks good," he said.

"It does."

"Looking good isn't quite the same as being good, is it?"

Bramble's ears tipped toward him.

"Not always."

Pip kept his eyes on the hill.

He wanted it to be the answer.

He would have to get closer to find out.

Chapter 12

The Hill Test

The empty farm cart rattled as Bramble pulled it past the orchard.

Pip rolled beside its low wooden bed.

"Does the cart have to come?"

"If we can't get it up empty, we shouldn't try with a capsule."

That made sense.

Pip had been hoping they could simply look at the hill, agree that he had found an excellent place, and go back.

The cart hit a small stone.

Its wheels bumped, and its wooden sides clattered.

Pip looked at the bed.

Dot would not enjoy that much.

"I'll watch for stones."

"And I'll watch the ground," Bramble said.

Behind them, Dot waited in the capsule with its panel folded away. Pip had told it they were going to check the hill.

Not move there.

Just check.

The cart path curved beyond the last apple tree. Two shallow wheel tracks ran through the grass.

Bramble stopped before the slope.

"Which way would you choose?"

Pip looked straight uphill.

Then he followed the wheel tracks. They took a longer route around a patch of thick grass.

"The path," he said.

"Why?"

"Because I don't fancy pushing a spaceship straight up that."

"Neither do I."

She stepped forward, pressing one hoof into the nearer track.

The ground held.

Pip followed.

For a little while, the cart rolled easily. He began to think they might finish the test before the sunlight left the top.

Then Bramble stopped so suddenly that he almost bumped the back board.

"What is it?"

She lifted a front hoof.

Dark mud clung to its edge.

The grass ahead looked ordinary. A little greener, perhaps.

Pip leaned close.

Water shone in the hoofprint.

"That's sneaky."

"Soft ground often is."

Bramble backed the cart a short way down the path. Pip moved aside to give her room.

"We can't take the capsule through that," she said.

Pip looked uphill. The soft patch stretched across both wheel tracks.

His good idea seemed to be turning into another muddy problem.

"Does that mean no hill?"

"Not yet. Can you see a way around?"

He examined the grass on either side.

To the left, the slope dipped toward the orchard. To the right, a narrow strip ran beside some low stones.

"That side looks drier."

"Let's find out."

Bramble left the cart and tested the strip with one hoof. Pip waited until she nodded before rolling onto it.

The ground felt firm beneath him.

He moved slowly, pressing his weight down.

No water appeared.

"Room for me," he said.

"But is there room for both wheels?"

Pip looked back at the cart, then at the strip.

"Only if we move that loose stone."

Bramble nudged it aside with a hoof.

They brought the cart around the soft patch. One wheel passed close to the remaining stones, but neither sank.

Pip watched every turn.

"Clear."

The path grew gentler near the top.

Bramble stopped beside a broad patch of short grass. She walked across it, testing the earth. Pip rolled behind her.

He expected to drift downhill when he stopped.

He did not.

"Flat," he said.

"Firm too."

The trees stood below them. Nothing blocked the sky.

Pip turned in a slow circle, imagining morning light spreading across the grass.

"This is the place."

Bramble looked down the route they had tested.

"I think so."

On the way back, she scraped a mark in the path before the soft ground. Pip pointed out the safe side as they guided the cart around it.

The hill had been his idea.

But now he knew how they could reach it, and he had not worked that out alone.

Chapter 13

A Ride for the Morning

The cart stood beside the capsule with its wheels blocked by wooden wedges.

Pip leaned against the back while Bramble checked each wedge.

"It isn't going anywhere," he said.

"That's what we want."

Two broad boards sloped from the grass to the cart's low bed. Bramble had laid an old folded blanket between the wooden sides.

Pip looked from the boards to the capsule.

This time, he could see the whole job before it began.

Dot stood in the doorway, holding the rope against the metal loop while Bramble drew it through.

Its yellow eyes looked faint.

"Are you all right?" Pip asked.

Dot nodded, but slowly.

Bramble set the rope down and lowered her nose beside the doorway.

The little robot climbed onto it. She carried Dot to a patch of dry grass beyond the wheels.

Then she returned to the rope.

Pip kept the cart steady.

Bramble pulled.

The capsule moved onto the boards with a scrape. Its weight pressed the cart springs down, and the wooden bed gave a small creak.

Pip felt the back board push against him.

He leaned harder.

Bramble paused with the rope tight.

"Still steady?"

"Yes."

She pulled again.

The capsule slid between the cart's sides and settled onto the blanket.

Pip waited.

He had learned that something arriving was not quite the same as something being safely in place.

Bramble eased the rope.

The capsule stayed still.

She placed folded pieces of sacking along its sides so it could not knock against the wood. Then she checked the wheels again.

"You can move."

Pip rolled back.

The cart did not follow.

For a moment, he simply enjoyed that.

Bramble carried Dot to the doorway. The robot climbed inside and pressed a small button.

A red light blinked once.

Then it went out.

"Very low," Dot said.

Pip moved close enough to see through the door.

"Will the sun tomorrow help?"

"Yes. But I must rest now."

Its voice sounded thinner than before.

Bramble lowered her head beside Pip.

"Is there anything else we need to know?"

Dot held up one finger.

"One short talk left."

Pip closed his mouth.

He had been about to ask whether the blanket was comfortable. Then whether Dot wanted the door open. Then whether robots dreamed.

None of those questions seemed worth using up the last talk.

Dot pointed to the dark panel folded against the capsule.

"Open this in sunlight. I will wake."

Bramble nodded.

"We'll bring you up the hill at first light."

Pip looked toward the orchard. The hilltop had lost its bright edge. Their tested path was already hard to see between the trees.

"We know the way," he said.

Dot rested one hand on the door frame.

Its fingers curled around the silver edge.

"You will come back?"

Pip stared at it.

"Of course."

The hand did not move.

Dot's dim eyes stayed fixed on him.

Pip remembered the tapping behind the buried door. The little sounds that had waited for an answer.

Perhaps morning seemed a very long way off from inside that capsule.

He wanted to say that nothing would go wrong. That the sun would shine all day and the search ship would find Dot and everything would be fixed.

But he could not make the sun shine.

He could not pull a ship across the sky.

He could get himself to this cart.

"I'll be here," he said. "At first light."

Dot's fingers loosened.

"Good."

It settled back inside. The yellow lights faded, and the tiny ticking stopped.

Pip stayed beside the doorway for another moment.

Then he looked at Bramble.

"First light," he said.

She nodded.

Pip rolled toward the vegetable patch, leaving the cart exactly where he would find it in the morning.

Chapter 14

Up Before the Sun

Pip rolled beside the cart and pressed his side against its back rail.

"Here," he whispered.

Bramble turned her head. In the pale light, her ears looked almost as tall as the orchard trees.

"I can see that."

"I was telling Dot."

The capsule sat snugly between the cart's wooden sides. Nothing stirred behind its little window.

Pip leaned closer.

"You don't have to wake up," he said. "I'm just here."

Bramble settled into the harness. The straps creaked as she stepped forward.

Pip pushed.

The cart did not move.

He pushed harder. The rail pressed a straight line into his round side.

"Wait," Bramble said.

Pip stopped pushing.

Yesterday, the empty cart had rattled along as if it wanted to climb the hill. This morning, it seemed to have changed its mind.

"It's much heavier," he said.

"Yes."

"Perhaps the capsule got heavier overnight."

"Perhaps we should start together."

Bramble planted her hooves. Pip shifted until the middle of his side rested against the rail.

"Ready?" she asked.

"Ready."

"Push."

He leaned forward as she pulled.

One wheel gave a small squeak. Then all four began to turn.

Pip rolled behind the cart, keeping close enough to push without bumping it. A blade of wet grass stuck to his cheek. He left it there.

They reached the orchard path.

Bramble slowed.

"Less now."

Pip eased back. The cart kept moving.

Through the apple trees, he could see the hill. Its top was pale against the sky. The sun had not reached it yet.

They were going to get there first.

That was a pleasing thought.

Then the path began to rise.

The back rail pressed harder against Pip. Bramble's hooves dug into the earth, and the wheels left dark lines behind them.

"Steady push," she called.

Pip pushed steadily.

He had not known that steady could be so much work.

His leaves brushed the rail. His skin felt warm despite the cold grass.

Ahead, Bramble turned toward the firm strip beside the soft patch they had found.

The cart's left wheel came close to the darker ground.

Pip wanted to shove it away.

"Hold there," Bramble said.

He held.

She took two short steps to the right. The front wheels turned. Slowly, the back wheels followed.

The soft patch slipped past beside him.

Pip let out a breath.

"I nearly pushed sideways."

"I'm glad you didn't."

"So am I."

They climbed a little farther before Bramble called for a rest. She kept the harness tight while Pip leaned against the back rail.

He could hear her breathing.

"Are you all right?" he asked.

"Yes. Are you?"

"I have a line in me."

"From the rail?"

"I hope so."

Bramble looked back. Her mouth twitched.

"It will go."

Pip glanced at the capsule. It had not shifted. Through the window, he could just make out Dot's small, still shape.

He pressed himself firmly against the wood.

"Tell me when."

Bramble rested for three more breaths.

"Now."

They moved again.

The last stretch was the steepest. Pip could see only the cart, the grass beneath it, and one of Bramble's ears. He waited for each call.

"Push."

He pushed.

"Easy."

He eased.

Then the rail stopped pressing so hard.

They had reached the flat place.

Bramble drew the cart onto the firm ground they had chosen and set stones snugly against the wheels. Only then did Pip roll away.

A thin strip of sunlight touched the capsule.

Pip looked downhill at the winding marks their wheels had made.

"We did that," he said.

Bramble lowered her head beside him.

"Yes."

Pip's side ached. There was grass on his cheek and a wooden line across his middle.

He had never looked more useful.

Chapter 15

The Waiting Job

A little green light blinked beside the sun panel.

Pip leaned toward it.

The light blinked again.

"Is that good?" he asked.

Bramble studied the marks beside it.

"I think we need Dot to tell us."

They had turned the cart so the panel faced the morning sun. Now sunlight lay across its dark surface, and Pip had rolled out of the way twice to keep his shadow off it.

There seemed to be nothing else to do.

He looked at the wheel stones.

They were firm.

He looked at the straps holding the capsule.

They were tight.

He looked at the green light.

Still blinking.

"Perhaps I could check the stones again."

"You could," Bramble said. "But they haven't gone anywhere."

"That is what a check would find out."

He checked them.

They had not gone anywhere.

When he rolled back, something clicked inside the capsule.

Pip stopped.

The little door opened a crack. Dot's face appeared in the gap.

"You came," it said.

Pip felt suddenly very glad that he had not gone to inspect something farther away.

"We did."

Dot looked past him.

"The hill."

"We brought that too," Pip said. "Well. We brought you to it."

Bramble leaned down near the door.

"How is the sun cell?"

Dot touched a small display inside. A narrow green strip glowed along its bottom.

"Filling."

"How long?" Pip asked.

"Most of the day."

Pip looked at the sun. It had barely cleared the orchard.

Most of the day was an enormous amount of sitting.

"Do you need something fixed while we wait?"

"Not now."

"Something pushed?"

"No."

"Something watched very carefully?"

Dot tipped its head.

"You can stay."

Pip glanced at Bramble. She was already folding her legs beneath her on the grass.

Staying sounded much like doing nothing.

But Dot had moved to the doorway and left a small space beside it, as though Pip might fit there.

He rolled close enough to talk without shading the panel.

"Is this all right?"

"Yes."

For a while, they listened to Bramble crop the grass.

Dot turned toward the sound.

"Does she need repairing?"

"No," Pip said. "She's eating."

"I can hear you," Bramble said.

"So can Dot. That was the trouble."

Dot made a tiny clicking sound. Pip thought it might be a laugh.

"Is there grass at your home?" he asked.

"Not near my house."

"What is near it?"

"A landing place. A repair room. Six blue doors."

"Which door is yours?"

"The yellow one."

Pip considered this.

"You didn't mention a yellow one."

"It is around the corner."

"Ah. A hidden door."

"Only from the front."

Dot's voice was stronger now. It described a shelf where it rested and a round lamp that grew dim when it was time to sleep.

Pip tried to imagine sleeping on a shelf.

His shelf would need very good legs.

"Who turns the lamp down?" he asked.

"My friends. If I forget."

"Do you forget often?"

"When I am making something."

Dot fell quiet.

Pip waited for the rest.

Instead, Dot looked down at its little metal feet.

"I wonder if they have left it bright."

Pip looked at the green strip. It was still very small.

He could not make the sun cell fill faster. He could not tell Dot what its friends were doing.

But he could move a little closer.

"What do you make?" he asked.

Dot lifted its head.

"Would you like to hear?"

"Yes," Pip said.

Dot began with a machine that sorted screws and had once sorted all the spoons as well.

Pip stayed beside the door.

This time, he did not look for another job.

Chapter 16

A Sky Full of Elsewhere

"Were there spoons on the moon?" Pip asked.

Dot paused.

"No. That happened at home."

"Oh."

Pip had been imagining silver spoons scattered over a moon. It had looked rather nice.

"I have a map," Dot said. "I can show you."

It touched a button beside the doorway. A small screen lit up inside the capsule.

Pip leaned toward it.

Bright dots filled the dark square. A thin line curled between them, passing a striped ball and a pale ring.

"Is that the way home?"

"Part of it."

Only part.

Pip studied the line again. It was longer than any path on the farm, even before he remembered that it was not really as short as it looked.

Dot touched the striped ball.

The picture grew.

A huge world filled the screen, wrapped in bands of orange and cream.

Pip forgot the ache in his side.

"It looks like something you could eat."

"It is mostly gas."

"Then perhaps not."

Bramble raised her head from the grass.

"That depends how hungry you are."

"No," Dot said firmly.

Pip laughed.

Dot showed them a moon with cracks across its white ground. Then a blue world with two small moons beside it.

"Do they both come up at night?" Pip asked.

"Sometimes."

"Two moons."

He tried to picture them above the barn. One could hang over the roof. The other could sit above the crooked fence.

There would be twice as much moon to look at.

Dot moved the picture again.

Pip edged closer to the door.

From there, he could see past the screen into the capsule. There was a little seat, a row of switches, and narrow spaces packed with things he did not know the names of.

The seat was exactly Dot-sized.

Pip looked at the doorway.

Then he looked at his own broad red side.

"Oh," he said.

Dot turned toward him.

"What?"

"Nothing."

But it was not nothing.

He imagined himself rolling across the white moon. He imagined Bramble testing strange ground with one careful hoof. He imagined looking out of the star window while the farm grew small below.

The doorway remained much too narrow.

"I would like to see it," he said.

"You are seeing it."

"I mean from there."

Dot's fingers rested on the screen.

"There is only one seat."

"I noticed."

"And the door—"

"I noticed that too."

Bramble got to her feet. She came to stand beside him, close enough that her shadow touched his leaves.

"You would need a bigger ship," she said.

"A much bigger ship."

"Yes."

"With a very wide door."

"Probably two."

Pip smiled, but only a little.

On the screen, the blue world turned. It went on turning whether he could visit it or not.

Dot reached toward the button.

"Shall I put the map away?"

Pip almost said yes.

Then he looked at the thin route leading away from the little mark that meant their farm.

"Not yet."

Dot waited.

"Show me which bit you do first."

The robot traced the route with one finger.

"To the meeting point. Then the search ship takes me farther."

Pip followed the line.

His part would end here, on the hill. There would be no moon beneath him. There would be grass, and probably a beet who still wanted more sunshine.

He felt disappointed.

He also wanted that little seat to reach the yellow door around the corner.

"Will you tell your friends about us?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Even though we stayed here?"

Dot looked at him.

"Of course."

Pip settled beside Bramble.

“All right,” he said. “Show me the rest of your way home.”

Chapter 17

The Long Grey Cloud

Pip was watching a beetle climb a grass stem when the sunlight vanished.

The beetle kept climbing.

Pip looked up.

A long grey cloud stretched across the sun. Its edges were white, but its middle was thick and dark.

Beside the doorway, the green light blinked more slowly.

Dot turned from the map and checked the charge display.

Pip leaned forward.

"Has it stopped?"

"No. It is gathering less."

"How much less?"

Dot watched the display for a moment.

"Much less."

Bramble stood and looked across the fields.

Pip followed her gaze.

A bright patch lay beyond the orchard. Sunlight shone on the far fence and the grass beside it.

"There," he said. "We could take the cart there."

Bramble did not answer at once.

Pip looked from the bright field to the shaded panel.

Every bit of him wanted to start moving.

"We know how to pull it now," he said.

"We do," Bramble said. "But that field is low. The trees will shade it later."

"We could move again."

"And spend the day moving?"

Pip glanced at Dot.

The robot was still watching the green strip.

"Would it charge while we pulled?" Pip asked.

"Some," Dot said. "If the panel stayed in the light."

The bright patch slid across the far fence.

One post went dull. Then another.

Pip watched the sunshine move away from the place he had chosen.

"Oh."

"The cloud is moving," Bramble said.

"So are we, sometimes."

"Yes. But the cloud doesn't have to pull a cart."

Pip looked up again.

The grey stretched beyond the orchard and over the barn. There was no neat little end waiting just behind the sun.

"How long will it take?"

"I don't know," Bramble said.

He wished she knew.

He wished Dot had a cloud button.

Dot switched off the map. The bright worlds disappeared, leaving a dark square.

"To save power," it said.

Pip had been enjoying the pictures. Now he was glad they were gone. He would not have liked to think of a whole moon using up the power Dot needed.

Bramble walked around the cart. She pressed her nose near a strap, then checked the stones.

Pip stayed by the door.

"Have we got enough?" he asked.

"Not to reach the meeting point."

"Not yet," Pip said.

"Not yet," Dot agreed.

That was better.

A little better.

Pip stared at the charge strip until his eyes felt strange. He looked away, then back.

It seemed exactly the same.

Perhaps it had grown a tiny bit.

Perhaps he only wanted it to.

"We chose this place because it gets sun longest," Bramble said.

"I know."

"The ground is firm. The panel is clear."

"I know that too."

His voice came out sharper than he meant.

Bramble's ears moved back.

Pip looked down at the flattened grass beneath him.

"Sorry."

She came to stand beside the cart.

"I wish I could pull the cloud away," she said.

Pip pictured a harness stretched across the sky.

"You'd need my help."

"I certainly would."

He smiled. Then he looked at the dull panel again.

The joke had not made the cloud smaller.

Dot sat in the doorway with its feet together. Pip rolled closer, leaving the panel clear.

"We're staying here," he said.

"For now," Bramble agreed.

Pip tried to listen to the farm. A bird called from the orchard. The cart gave a small wooden creak.

Waiting had felt useful while Dot told stories.

Now every slow blink seemed to ask him why he was doing nothing.

He stayed beside his friend, but he could not stop watching the sky.

Chapter 18

No More Guessing

A bright gap opened near the edge of the cloud.

Pip watched it widen. Sunlight touched the orchard, then a strip of grass halfway up the hill.

The sun panel stayed dull.

"What if we tipped it?" he asked.

Bramble lifted her head.

"Tipped what?"

"The panel. Not the cart."

He looked at the dark square. It lay nearly flat above the capsule, with one edge raised toward the part of the sky that had been sunny.

"The light is over there now."

Bramble stepped closer.

"Pip, we can't keep changing things because we're worried."

"I'm not only worried. I'm looking."

His voice sounded sharp again.

He stopped.

Bramble looked from him to the panel.

"I know," she said. "But if we pull the wrong part, we might break the thing that is still working."

Pip had been thinking of getting his side beneath the edge and lifting.

Now he noticed a thin wire running from the panel into the capsule.

He could easily have pulled that tight.

"I wasn't going to lift the whole ship," he said.

"I know you weren't."

"But you thought I was rushing."

"A little."

Pip looked at the bright gap. It would not stay there while they talked forever.

That did not mean he knew how the panel worked.

"Dot," he said, "can you test an idea before we do it?"

Dot turned from the charge display.

"Which idea?"

"Pointing the panel at that bright bit. Only the panel. Without tugging any wires."

Dot climbed onto the low rim beside it. Its feet made small clicks on the metal.

Pip stayed where he was.

That was harder than asking.

Dot examined the hinge beneath the panel. Then it looked at the sky.

"This edge can lift," it said. "There is a support with three notches."

"Would lifting it help?" Bramble asked.

"I can measure."

Dot held a little flat sensor toward the bright gap. Numbers appeared on its wrist.

Pip could not read them from below.

He tried not to ask before Dot had finished.

The robot lowered the sensor, checked it again, then pointed it toward the cloud.

"Yes," it said. "A small lift should help."

Pip's leaves stirred.

"How small?"

"The first notch."

Bramble lowered her head beside him.

"I should have asked what you meant before I said no."

"You didn't quite say no."

"I stood in a very no sort of way."

Pip looked at her four firmly planted hooves.

"You did."

Dot released a little catch.

"Bramble, lift here with your nose. Slowly."

She slid her nose under the smooth edge.

Pip watched the wire.

It curved loosely beside the hinge. As the panel rose, the curve grew shallower.

"Still loose," he reported.

Dot guided the support into its first notch.

"Stop."

Bramble stopped.

The panel stayed up.

Nothing cracked. Nothing tipped. The wire still had a small, comfortable bend.

Dot checked the display.

Pip waited through one blink of the green light.

Then another.

They came closer together now.

"More power," Dot said.

"How much more?"

"Enough to make this worth doing."

Pip looked up at the panel. It had moved less than the width of one of Bramble's ears.

Such a little change.

He had wanted to do something enormous.

"Shall we lift it to the next notch?" he asked.

Dot checked the sensor.

"No. This is better."

"All right."

Bramble's ears tipped toward him.

Pip settled on the grass, clear of the sunlight.

Above him, the little green light blinked steadily faster.

Chapter 19

Grass in the Fan

The edge of the cloud thinned until Pip could see the sun through it.

Then the whole hill brightened.

Warmth spread across his skin. The panel shone, and Dot bent over the charge display.

"Better?" Pip asked.

"Much better."

Pip let himself look away from the green strip.

The orchard leaves were turning over in the wind. Their pale undersides flashed between the branches. A few loose blades of cut grass skipped past the cart.

Bramble flicked one from her nose.

Dot climbed through the capsule door.

"I can test the cooling fan now."

Pip rolled nearer, but not too near.

"How will we know if it works?"

"It will turn smoothly. Air will come through this opening."

Dot pointed to a round hole low on the capsule's side. Pip could see the fan inside it.

Bramble came around the cart.

"The blades still look straight," she said.

Pip remembered the padded clamp and her careful work at the bench. He hoped the fan remembered too.

Dot touched a switch.

A low hum began.

Pip's leaves trembled in the small stream of air.

"It's blowing on me."

"That is good," Dot said.

"For both of us," Pip said. "I was getting warm."

The hum grew a little stronger.

Then a gust swept over the hill.

Grass hissed against Pip's side. A dry leaf spun under the cart, followed by a loose tangle of thin stalks.

One stalk lifted toward the opening.

There was a sharp tick.

The hum stopped.

Pip went cold despite the sun.

"Dot?"

"Switched off."

Dot was already at the doorway.

A strand of grass stuck out between two fan blades.

Pip stared at it.

The strand was so thin that he could hardly believe it had stopped anything. A beet could have sat on it without noticing.

"Is it bent again?" Bramble asked.

"I must check."

Dot climbed down beside the opening. It pulled the strand free with both hands.

The grass slid out slowly.

Pip wanted to tell it to hurry.

Instead, he watched Dot lay the stalk on the cart.

The robot turned each blade gently.

Once.

Twice.

"No damage," it said.

Bramble let out a long breath.

Pip did too.

"Then we can try again."

Dot looked toward the loose grass moving over the hill.

"Not yet."

Another gust pressed Pip's leaves flat.

He watched three more stalks tumble past the wheel.

"Oh."

Bramble began nosing loose grass away from the cart. Pip rolled toward a little pile and leaned over it.

The grass beneath him stayed put.

The grass beside him blew away.

He leaned farther.

A stalk slid past his cheek and vanished under the capsule.

"I can hold some of it," he said.

"Not all of it," Bramble said.

Pip looked across the hillside.

There was a great deal of grass.

Even for a very large tomato.

Bramble stopped sweeping.

"We could clear this patch, but more will blow in."

"And I cannot watch the opening during flight," Dot said.

Pip looked at the round hole again.

"What about covering it?"

"The air must pass through."

"A cover with holes, then."

Dot nodded.

"Small holes. Smaller than the spaces between the blades."

Bramble's ears rose.

"Something that keeps things out but lets air in."

"Like a fence for the fan," Pip said.

He pictured a tiny gate. Then he decided the fan probably did not need a gate.

Dot picked up the long grass stalk.

"This was enough to stop it," it said.

Pip looked from the stalk to the brightening charge display.

They had saved the fan from breaking.

Now they had to keep it saved.

Chapter 20

A Little Room for Air

Bramble came back up the hill carrying something that flashed between her teeth.

Pip rolled a little way to meet her.

"Did you find a fence?"

She set the thing on the cart.

It was a piece of fine wire mesh. Small square holes covered it from edge to edge.

"Behind the empty seed trays," she said. "I remembered seeing it."

Pip leaned close.

He could see the wood beneath it through dozens of tiny squares.

"Lots of windows. No doors."

Dot examined the mesh. It pressed one finger through a hole, then held a strand of grass against it.

The strand did not fit.

"This will work."

Pip looked toward the sun.

It hung low beyond the fields. Their shadows stretched across the hill, much longer and thinner than they ought to be.

His shadow looked like a tomato on a stick.

"Can we finish before the light goes?"

"If you both help," Dot said.

It pulled a small tool from inside the capsule and pointed to the fan opening.

"The cover needs to stand away from the blades. I must bend the mesh around the rim."

Bramble lifted it carefully by one corner.

The other corner sprang upward.

Dot caught it.

Pip stopped himself from rolling in.

There were wire ends along the edge. He did not want those pressed into his skin.

"Where can I help without getting holes in me?"

Dot looked at the mesh, then at Pip.

"We need something smooth between you and the wire."

Bramble went to the things beside the cart. She brought back a folded sack and laid it over the lower edge.

Dot checked the fold.

"Here. Lean against this part. Very gently."

Pip moved until the sack touched his side.

"Enough?"

"A little more."

He leaned.

The mesh curved around the rim.

"Stop there."

Pip stopped.

Bramble held the upper edge with her teeth. Dot worked between them, fastening one corner, then bending the next part into place.

Pip could hear tiny clicks from the tool.

A breeze tugged at the sack.

He wanted to look down and see whether it was slipping, but looking down would mean moving.

"Is the sack still right?"

Dot checked.

"Yes."

Pip held still.

His side began to ache in the same place the cart rail had pressed that morning.

Bramble's jaw shifted.

Dot looked up.

"Nearly."

Pip thought nearly was a very long word for something that meant soon.

At last Dot fastened the bottom corner.

"Release slowly."

Bramble let go.

Pip eased away.

The mesh stayed in place, curved over the opening like a shallow basket.

Dot tucked every sharp end inward and checked the space behind it.

Pip inspected his side.

No holes.

A good result.

Dot climbed inside.

"Stand clear."

Pip rolled beside Bramble.

The fan began to hum.

Air whispered through the little squares. The mesh trembled, but it did not touch the blades.

A loose blade of grass blew against the cover.

Pip stiffened.

The grass caught across two squares. Its free end fluttered.

The fan kept turning.

Dot let it run a little longer, then switched it off.

"Cooling is good."

Bramble lowered her head and blew the grass away from the cover.

Pip grinned.

Their fence worked.

A clear note sounded inside the capsule.

Dot turned to the charge display.

The green strip reached all the way across.

"Full," it said.

For a moment, Pip forgot his aching side.

Below them, the last sunlight slipped off the barn roof.

He looked at the capsule, with its clean window and its new little fence.

“Is it ready?”
Dot rested one hand beside the door.
“Now we must check everything for launch.”

Chapter 21

The Uneven Ground

Two small metal feet unfolded beneath the capsule.

Pip watched them reach toward the grass. On the other side of the cart, something clicked as the third foot opened.

Dot leaned out of the doorway.

"They will lift the capsule clear. Then we can move the cart."

Bramble checked that the wheels were still blocked.

Pip waited behind the cart. He had a job ready, but not yet.

The feet touched down.

A low whir came from inside the ship.

Slowly, the capsule rose. A narrow space appeared between its silver bottom and the wooden cart.

Pip could see daylight through it.

Well, evening light.

Enough light to see that it was working.

"Clear," Dot said.

Bramble pulled the wheel stones away and took hold of the cart's front rope.

Pip leaned against the back rail.

Together they rolled the empty cart out from beneath the capsule.

Without the ship, it felt almost silly.

Pip could have pushed it halfway down the hill.

He stopped beside Bramble instead.

Behind them came a soft squelch.

Pip turned.

One of the capsule's feet had sunk into the ground.

Only a little.

But the round window was no longer quite straight.

"Dot."

The whir stopped.

Dot looked out.

Pip was already rolling toward the low side. He could put himself beneath it. He could give it one quick shove before it went any farther.

Then he saw the narrow foot.

A shove would not make that foot wider.

It might only tip the capsule onto the other two.

He stopped short of the metal.

"The ground is giving way."

Bramble came beside him. She pressed one hoof into the grass near the sunken foot.

The surface held for a moment.

Then dark water welled around the edge of her hoof.

Pip stared.

"It looked dry."

"On top," she said.

She lifted her hoof. Damp earth clung beneath it.

"The rain from that storm is still down there."

"But we tested this place."

"With our feet and the cart wheels." Bramble looked at the small metal pads. "These are much narrower."

Dot climbed down to the doorway's lowest edge.

"The capsule's weight is on three small points now."

Pip looked toward the cart.

Its wheels had made shallow marks, but none had sunk like that.

"Can you pull the feet back up?"

"Not without something underneath."

Bramble moved toward the higher side.

"Could we shift it a little?"

Pip looked at the grass. One patch looked much like another. Firm blades above. Hidden mud below.

"We'd still be guessing."

Bramble stopped.

He wished he had a better answer ready.

He looked at the sunken foot again. Wet earth bulged around its edge, like mud squeezing past a stone in the ditch.

"It needs more ground to stand on," he said.

Dot tilted its head.

"A wider base?"

"Yes. Something that spreads the weight. Not just another patch that looks dry."

Bramble's ears turned toward him.

"Boards," she said.

"Thick ones?"

"Thick ones."

Pip glanced at the barn below. The path was growing dim between the orchard trees.

He was tired. Bramble had already made one trip to the shed. The capsule had a full sun cell, and for a few lovely moments he had thought the hard work was finished.

But he did not lean against the ship.

"We need a proper base," he said. "Before we move anything."

Bramble touched his leaves lightly with her nose.

"Good stopping."

Pip looked at the crooked window.

It was not a grand thing to be good at.

Just now, he was very glad he had done it.

Chapter 22

A Place to Stand

The rope tightened, and the boards scraped another short distance up the path.

Pip pushed against their back ends.

"Stop," Bramble said through her teeth.

He stopped.

She set down the rope and lowered her head. Pip could hear her breathing. His own side felt as though every piece of wood on the farm had pressed against it.

The boards lay in a bundle on two crosspieces. Bramble had tied them together at the shed. Now they had only the last part of the hill to climb.

Only was becoming one of Pip's least favourite words.

"Ready?" he asked.

"Not quite."

He waited.

Above them, a small light shone from the capsule door. Dot stood beside it, watching.

Pip looked away from the tilted ship. Looking at it made him want to push before Bramble picked up the rope.

At last she lifted her head.

"Now."

She pulled. Pip pushed.

The bundle scraped over the crest and onto the flat ground.

Bramble dropped the rope.

"There."

Pip rolled aside.

He had never been so pleased to stop pushing something.

Dot came down to inspect the boards. It walked along each one, touching the thick wood.

"These will spread the weight."

"How do we get them under the feet?" Pip asked.

Dot pointed beneath the capsule.

"One foot at a time. The other two will hold while I shorten the third."

Bramble looked at the leaning ship.

"Will it tip?"

"I can lower the other feet first. But the boards must stay together."

Pip studied the bundle.

"I can hold this side."

Bramble followed his gaze.

"And I can pull from the other end."

Dot looked between them.

"Slowly."

"We know that bit," Pip said.

Then he glanced at Bramble.

"I know it now."

They untied the boards and laid the first two side by side. Bramble pulled a rope looped around their ends while Pip leaned against the outer edge.

The wood moved over the grass.

Then one board caught.

The other began to slide ahead.

"Stop," Pip called.

Bramble set down the rope at once.

A thick root showed beneath the caught corner. Pip could feel the board trying to twist against him.

"We need to lift that end."

Bramble worked her nose beneath it. Dot pushed a thin scrap of wood under the corner.

The board rose just enough.

They tried again.

This time, both boards slid together.

Dot shortened the sunken foot. Wet soil clung to its metal pad as it lifted.

Bramble pulled the boards into place.

Pip held the side steady until Dot lowered the foot onto the wood.

The capsule shifted.

Pip went still.

"Settling," Dot said. "That is all."

They fitted the next boards beside the first. Bramble's rope dragged through the damp grass. Pip braced the edge again, keeping the growing platform square while she pulled.

His side ached.

He wanted to move to a fresh spot.

"Can I change sides?" he asked.

"After this foot comes down," Dot said.

So he waited.

The metal pad touched the wood.

"Now."

Pip eased away and rolled around the platform. Bramble rested her forehead against the capsule for a moment before taking up the rope again.

The final board took three tries.

On the third, it slid snugly into place.

Dot lowered the last foot, then checked a small glowing line inside the doorway.

"A little higher here."

The foot lengthened with a soft whir.

The line changed colour.

"Level."

Pip looked up.

The window sat straight. The door no longer leaned toward the grass.

Bramble stepped back beside him.

The ship stood on their boards, and the boards lay broad and firm beneath it.

This time, nothing sank.

Chapter 23

Things to Say Before Dawn

Pip kept looking for another job.

There was the rope, but Bramble had already coiled it beside the cart.

There was the sack, but Dot had folded it.

There were the boards beneath the capsule, but they were exactly where boards beneath a capsule ought to be.

Pip rolled a little closer to the door.

"Should we check the fan cover again?"

Dot looked out.

"I checked it."

"The straps?"

"They are off."

Pip knew that. He had watched Bramble remove them.

He looked at the small pile of straps beside the cart.

"Oh. Yes."

Bramble folded her legs beneath her on the grass.

"You could sit here."

"I am sitting."

"Nearer, then."

Pip rolled beside her.

The capsule's light fell across her front hooves. Beyond it, the farm was dark. Pip could make out the barn roof, but not the crooked fence.

Dot sat in the doorway with its feet on the lowest step.

For a while, nobody spoke.

Pip had wanted the work finished so badly.

Now it was finished, and he did not like how quiet everything had become.

"Will the search ship be big?" he asked.

"Much bigger than this capsule."

"Big enough for a tomato?"

"Yes."

Dot said it simply.

Pip looked toward the dark farm.

He could imagine a wide door and a great window full of stars. He could also imagine Bramble coming to the vegetable patch and finding his place empty.

"I think I'll stay here," he said.

Dot nodded.

"You would not fit in this door anyway."

"I was being grand about it."

Bramble made a soft sound through her nose.

Dot's head tipped sideways.

"Was I meant to say something else?"

"No," Pip said. "You said the true thing."

The quiet returned.

This time, Pip knew what he wanted to say. That did not make saying it easy.

"I'll miss you."

Dot's feet stopped swinging.

"I will miss you too."

Bramble stretched her nose toward the doorway. Dot rested one little hand against it.

Pip wished he had a hand.

Then he leaned gently against Bramble's shoulder, and that helped.

"What if you forget what we sound like?" he asked.

"I can keep sounds."

"Really?"

Dot touched the side of its head.

Pip considered saying something important enough to keep.

Nothing came.

Bramble lifted one hoof and tapped the wooden platform.

Tock. Tock. Tock.

Pip looked at her.

"Our knock," he said.

Dot straightened.

"From outside the capsule."

"You answered," Pip said.

"I hoped you would hear."

"We did."

He remembered the little sounds behind the metal. They had seemed so small for something that mattered so much.

"Let's make it our greeting," he said. "Not just a knock because somebody is stuck."

Bramble tapped again, slowly.

Tock. Tock. Tock.

"Three," she said. "With a little space after each."

Dot copied her on the doorframe.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

Pip leaned against the cart's side rail, eased back, then leaned again.

Thup. Thup. Thup.

His greeting was not very tidy.

"It sounds different," he said.

"It is still three," Dot told him.

Bramble's ears tipped toward Pip.

"And it sounds like you."

Dot climbed inside and returned carrying a little square radio. It placed it beside Bramble's hoof.

"For hearing me," it said. "When I am far enough away that tapping will not work."

Pip looked at the small speaker.

Then he looked at Dot.

He could not think of anything grand to say.

So he tapped the cart three times again.

Dot answered from the doorway.

Chapter 24

The Last Careful Step

A pale line appeared beyond the fields.

Dot stood up.

"It is time for the launch check."

Pip looked toward the lightening sky. He had watched for dawn all night. Now he wished it would take a little longer.

Bramble rose carefully and shook grass from her coat.

"What do you need us to do?"

"Stay beside the base while I check the weight on each foot. Then move behind the cart."

Dot pointed to the cart, parked well away from the capsule.

Pip looked at the space between them.

"That far?"

"The launch air will be strong."

"All right."

Dot climbed inside.

A low hum came through the open door. Small lights glowed around the window.

Pip watched the nearest foot.

It pressed against the board with a faint wooden creak.

"Front support," Dot called.

The hum changed.

Another foot settled more firmly.

Pip saw a dark line open between two boards.

At first, it was no wider than a grass blade.

Then the outer board moved.

"Stop," he said.

The hum cut off.

Pip rolled against the side of the platform. The thick edge met his skin.

He leaned just enough to keep it from sliding farther.

Bramble was beside him in two steps.

"Which one?"

"This one. Under the near foot."

She lowered her head.

The board lay slightly higher at one end. Beneath it, a crosspiece had pressed into the soft ground.

Pip could feel the wood pushing back.

"Can you hold it?" Bramble asked.

"Yes."

He hoped the answer would stay true.

Dot appeared in the doorway.

"Do not push it inward. Hold it where it is."

Pip stopped trying to do anything except stay still.

Bramble looked beneath the board.

"There's a gap here. I need a wedge."

"By the rope," Dot said. "The pointed offcut."

Bramble turned toward the pile beside the cart.

Pip watched her go.

The board gave a small creak.

He wanted her to run.

But she had to choose the right piece. She nudged one aside, picked up another, and came back with a thick wedge between her teeth.

She laid it beside the gap.

"I'm going to press this in," she told him. "You may feel it move."

Pip fixed his eyes on a knot in the wood.

"All right."

Bramble pushed the wedge with her nose. Then she placed the flat of her hoof against its broad end.

The board lifted slightly against Pip.

He nearly rolled away.

"Still hold," Dot said.

He held.

Bramble pressed again.

The wedge slid deeper beneath the board and stopped.

She took her hoof away.

Pip could no longer feel the same sideways pressure, but he stayed where he was.

Dot checked the small glowing line inside.

Then it lowered the launch foot a little more.

Weight settled onto the repaired corner.

Nothing moved.

"Again," Bramble said.

Dot eased the foot up, then down.

Pip watched the knot.

It stayed exactly where it had been.

Dot climbed down and inspected the wedge. It checked both sides, then looked along the platform.

"The base is safe."

Pip did not move quite yet.

"Safe for me to roll away?"

"Yes, Pip."

He eased back.

The board stayed firm.

Only then did he notice the deep mark along his side.

Bramble brushed her nose against his leaves.

"Come on."

He rolled beside her toward the cart. She carried the little radio by its strap.

Behind them, the hum began again.

Pip turned before they reached their waiting place.

The capsule stood straight against the pale sky, with all three feet resting firmly on the boards.

He kept rolling until he was clear.

Chapter 25

A Small Light Going Up

Dot stood in the little doorway.

Behind it, the lights inside the capsule glowed green.

Pip wanted to call out another question.

He could ask whether the fan was working. Whether the window was clean enough. Whether Dot had checked the charge one last time.

But Dot had checked.

Pip knew it had.

Bramble set the radio on the grass between them.

"Can you hear us?" she asked.

A tiny crackle came from the speaker.

"Yes."

Pip looked from the radio to the doorway. Dot was close enough that he could hear its real voice too.

That would not last.

"Your base is still straight," Pip said.

Dot glanced down.

"Thank you."

"I wasn't asking you to check again."

"I know."

The pale line above the fields spread higher. Pip could see the fence now, and the tops of the bean poles.

Dot lifted one small hand.

Pip leaned forward, then stopped.

He was meant to stay behind the cart.

Bramble raised her nose.

"Safe journey."

"Find your yellow door," Pip said.

"I will."

Dot stepped inside.

Its hand rested on the edge of the door.

For a moment, Pip could still see its little feet.

He wanted the moment to stay.

But Dot could not go home with the door open.

"All right," Pip said softly.

The door closed.

A neat seam appeared where his friend had been.

Pip stared at it.

The radio crackled.

"Ready for lift."

The low hum became a deep, steady sound. Grass flattened around the platform. A loose corner of the sack fluttered beside the cart.

Bramble stood close enough for Pip to feel her shoulder against his leaves.

The capsule trembled.

Pip looked at the boards.

They held.

The three metal feet rose together, leaving small dark marks on the wood.

"It's up," Pip whispered.

He had known it was a space capsule. He had seen the map and the lights and the little pilot.

Still, some part of him had expected it to remain a silver thing on their farm.

Now daylight showed beneath it.

The capsule rose above Bramble's ears.

Pip tipped back to follow.

Air rushed over him, bending his leaves. He could smell damp earth from the launch base.

The ship climbed past the orchard trees.

Its feet folded away.

Then the deep sound grew thinner, and the silver shape began to shrink.

Pip kept looking.

"There," Bramble said.

A bright point was moving across the pale sky.

It did not twinkle like the stars he knew. It travelled steadily toward the place above the farm.

"The search ship?" Pip asked.

The radio hissed.

"Search light found," Dot said.

Pip watched the smaller light climb toward the moving one.

He could no longer make out the capsule's window.

Then he could no longer make out the capsule at all.

There were only two lights.

Pip tried not to blink.

One light drew closer to the other. For a moment, they seemed to sit side by side.

The radio went quiet.

Pip waited.

A bird called from the orchard.

He wished it would be quiet too.

Then the speaker clicked.

"Pip? Bramble?"

"We're here," Pip said at once.

"I have reached the search ship."

Bramble let out a long breath.

Pip leaned against her front leg.

"Are they taking you home?"

"Yes."

Dot's voice sounded small through the speaker, but clear.

"I told them about you."

Pip looked at the boards, the rope, and the empty place above the hill.

"Both of us?"

"Both of you."

A little crackle followed.

“Thank you for staying.”
Pip watched the moving light carry his friend across the dawn.
“Thank you for answering,” he said.

Chapter 26

Three Taps from Far Away

"Just there," Bramble said.

Pip leaned against the gate.

Its bottom corner scraped the path, then lifted clear as Bramble pushed a flat stone beneath the post.

"Hold it."

He held it.

A fly landed on his leaves.

Pip left it alone.

Bramble pressed the earth around the stone with her hoof.

"Try now."

Pip rolled back. The gate swung halfway shut without scraping.

Bramble nudged it open again.

"Better."

"Not a very exciting gate," Pip said.

"No."

"But a good one."

"Now it is."

Pip watched her swing it once more. He liked the little space between the wood and the ground. Yesterday, there had been no space. Today, there was.

That was their doing.

He rolled beside Bramble toward the shed.

The farm had grown familiar again in the days since Dot left. Beans climbed their poles. The ditch carried water toward the pond. There were tools to put away and things that needed holding steady.

Pip still looked up whenever a bright point moved across the sky.

Sometimes it was a bird.

Once it had been a floating seed, much closer than he thought.

He had said hello anyway.

Inside the open shed, Dot's radio sat on a low shelf. Bramble had put it where Pip could see its little light from the doorway.

The light was dark.

Pip looked away before he could begin watching it too hard.

"Shall we check the lower fence?" he asked.

"After a rest."

"I could rest beside the lower fence."

"That sounds suspiciously like working."

"It might fool the fence."

Bramble began to answer.

Tick.

Pip stopped.

Tick. Tick.

The sound came from the shelf.

Bramble's ears stood straight up.

Pip stared at the radio. A green light shone beside its speaker.

"Was that—"

"Shh," Bramble said.

A soft crackle filled the shed.

Then a familiar voice spoke.

"Three taps. Hello, Pip. Hello, Bramble."

Pip rolled forward so quickly that he nearly bumped the shelf.

He stopped himself just short of it.

"Dot!"

The radio crackled again.

"This message comes from home. I am beside the yellow door."

Pip looked at Bramble.

She had lowered her head until her nose was almost beside the speaker.

"My friends left the lamp bright," Dot said. "They were waiting."

Pip's leaves lifted.

He could picture it. Not very clearly, but enough. A round lamp. A shelf. Someone turning toward a door that had finally opened.

"The capsule is in the repair room. They asked who made the fan cover."

Bramble's ears tipped forward.

"I told them we did."

Pip leaned gently against her leg.

"Good," he whispered.

"I have shown them where the farm is," Dot went on. "It is on our map now. When I look at your star, I know which way to say hello."

There was a pause.

Pip listened to a faint clicking behind Dot's voice.

"I hope the beans are well. I hope Pip has no holes. I will send another message."

Three small taps sounded through the speaker.

Then the green light went dark.

For a moment, Pip did not move.

"Do you think Dot can hear us?" he asked.

"I don't know."

Bramble touched the radio lightly with her nose.

Pip looked through the doorway. Beyond the gate, the bean poles stood in crooked rows. The ditch curved past them toward the pond.

Somewhere far away, Dot had a map with this place on it.

"We'd better check the beans," he said. "So we have something to tell Dot."

Bramble tapped the shelf three times.

Pip waited for the last tap, then rolled beside her into the sunshine.

The End

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Steve Smythe is a creative technologist, and the co-founder and creator of AI Global Entertainment and Rough Draft Maker — the drafting studio built on a simple belief: writing is rewriting, and every writer deserves to start from a draft instead of a blank page.

A Tomato, a Donkey, and the Stars grew from his own story idea, drafted with the studio he built. Pip's lesson is one he keeps relearning: being big does not mean doing everything yourself.

A big adventure starts with a little help.



Pip is a giant tomato who longs to do something important. Bramble is a donkey who likes to think before she takes a step. When they find a space capsule buried on their farm, Pip is ready for the biggest adventure ever. But inside is a tiny robot with a broken ship—and a very long way to go home. With farm tools, bright ideas, and a few muddy mistakes, the friends set out to help. Pip soon discovers that being big does not mean doing everything yourself. Sometimes the most important thing you can do is stop, listen, and trust a friend.

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